

their conventional counterparts in terms of imaging capabilities and ease of use, and the day isn't far when all photography will be completely digital. Digital photography has fewer limitations: you can take loads of pictures without the fear of running out of film or getting stuck with a dud. And you get to check the quality of your picture instantly—whether it is worth keeping or whether you'd be better off deleting it and shooting again. And the photographs can be uploaded and distributed on the Net within minutes.

Alternatively, you could also invest in a flatbed scanner. Available today in a variety of price ranges and features, they are the cheapest way to digitise your existing photographs. But there's always the cost of printing your photographs first, which makes it a solution only if you plan to work with a small number. If you regularly scan every print that comes back from the developers, you should seriously think about getting a digital camera.

Vanity fair

If you have your own Web space, you can post your digital images online for other people to view and also experiment with Web design. You can register a domain and rent some server space or use a free hosting site such as **Yahoo!**, **Geocities** and **Tripod**. Get a Web site authoring tool like Frontpage or VisualSite 3.0 (www.futuretrendsoft.com). Frontpage 2002 even offers a cool 'Photo gallery creation' feature that can make an online photo album for you. "I picked up some source code from gallery.sourceforge.net to create my own photo gallery. It was pretty easy to set up, and there are no restrictions against linking my images to www.hotornot.com or at forums," says Sacs, who created his own photo gallery containing 400 odd photographs.

The best way to present pictures online, especially if there are lots of them, is to make thumbnails—small copies of the larger images—that people can use as an index. This saves on bandwidth and lets viewers choose the images. They can browse through the thumbnails and view actual sizes of only the pictures they want to see. Building a thumbnail index is not very difficult if you have some knowledge of HTML and software packages such as Web Thumbnailer (www.freedomloads-center.com) make it easier for you.

An online album lets you upload as many photos as you like. You can cate-

gorise them by creating albums for every vacation you take, each birthday party or special event. While most online sites offer storage space that would satisfy even the most trigger-happy shutterbug, some make additional storage space available for a small fee.

Choosing the right showcase

The intent of most photo album sites is to allow consumers to upload pictures, invite friends to view them, or send photo greeting cards, while they try and sell you ancillary merchandise and services. Most sites offer storage, uploading, and photo-sharing tools as their basic services but they vary in terms of the premium services offered as well as the price. Which one suits you best depends on how you use your virtual gallery.

The quality of service that you can get out of these sites is completely dependent on which side of the world you live in. While you can use any of the services provided in the table 'Photo Finish', to upload and view images, ordering prints can prove to be an entirely different proposition. Most online album sites have no base in India, and you would have to tolerate delays with the post office and international mail for getting your prints. These would be irrelevant to your relatives in the US, though. The only Photo album site with a photo lab based in India is www.photojagat.com. They have an alliance with Speedpost and DTDC, which ensures quick delivery of photos to virtually any part of the country.

 **DotPhoto:** If you are a heavy digital camera user who sends greeting cards and pictures to friends and family on a regular basis, this site is for you. It offers several subscription plans, which will reduce printing costs. Join dotphoto.com for a \$60 bulk photo account (approx Rs 3,000) and you get 372 photos. At \$1.99 (approx Rs 100) per order, shipping is cheap. This is the only site where you can add sound clips to your digital photos. If you would like to sell prints of your photos, DotPhoto lets you specify royalty rates, so it's a site for professional photographers too.
www.dotphoto.com

 **Kodak Picture Center:** This site is more focused towards developing prints rather than viewing them online. Loading images is

Creating your own Photo Gallery

Here's a step-by-step guide on creating an online photo gallery.

Step 1: Digitising your photos

If you have developed pictures, scan them in either GIF or JPG format. If you have a digital camera, use the bundled software to connect to your PC and transfer the images.

Step 2: Editing and resizing

You can upload the images either unedited, or after you've made changes using an image editing software. The resolution of the images depends on your needs—whether they are for Web viewing or printing. It's best to upload the largest file size that your Internet connection can afford; this gives your viewers the choice to obtain high quality prints.

Step 3: Registering with a photo album service

There are several sites to choose from (refer table, 'Photo Finish'). Find a service where you can display them free of cost—users of **Yahoo!** and **Hot-mail** are entitled to a free online photo album.

Decide on a particular site to host your images depending on the total amount of space you want and whether you would like to avail of printing services.

Step 4: Uploading

Most sites have an easy upload procedure, similar to adding an attachment to your mail.

Some provide desktop utilities, for others you have to use Web-based forms.

Step 5: Separating into albums

You can segregate your pictures in different categories pertaining to an event, like you would do in a proper album, instead of having all your images in one page.

Step 6: Inviting family and friends

Send invitations and links to friends and relatives in your address book and allow them to leave comments at your gallery. Most online album sites provide this service.

